

V14 Virtual Ethical Leadership and Decision-Making Team

Description & Eligibility

Teams will research and evaluate an ethical challenge, developing informed, solutions-focused responses to a provided case study. Competing teams will submit a research paper, complete an objective test, and deliver a presentation highlighting proposed solutions to the ethical challenge and lessons learned. This national event will be submitted and judged virtually. Awards will be presented at the National Leadership Conference. Any middle level, secondary, or postsecondary contestant may enter this event. A team will consist of 2–4 contestants. There are no restrictions on the number of entries per chapter or per state. Teams that do not submit an entry following the topic listed below or do not follow the Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and Artificial Intelligence Usage and Citation Policy will be disqualified.

Topic

Student Athlete Offered Money to Promote a Product She Doesn't Use. Devon is a junior distance runner with a growing following online, mostly other high school athletes who watch her training videos and race breakdowns. She is careful about what she posts and proud that people trust her.

A recovery drink company reaches out with an offer: four thousand dollars (\$4,000) for six posts across the season. The money would cover her club fees, travel to two out-of-state meets, and a chunk of what her family has been putting on a credit card.

Devon tries the drink. She does not like it, and more importantly, she does not think it does anything. She already uses a cheaper product that works fine for her.

The company's contract does not require her to say she uses the drink daily. It requires six posts featuring the product, tagged and disclosed as sponsored. Everything about it is legal and above board.

Devon's coach says every athlete she knows takes these deals, and that a sponsorship post is understood by everyone to be an advertisement, not a personal recommendation. Her teammate points out that Devon's audience is mostly other teenagers who look up to her and might buy something they cannot really afford because Devon appeared to endorse it.

Devon's mother has not said much, except that the credit card balance is real.

The company needs an answer by Friday.

Consider the following:

- Should Devon accept the offer?
- Does a sponsorship disclosure fully solve the honesty problem, or only part of it?
- Does it change your answer that her audience is mostly teenagers?
- Is there a version of this deal Devon could accept in good conscience?

Competition Notes

- AI Policy Level 2 *Permitted with Citation*
- Contest Registration
 - Advisors register contestants for the event using the Membership Registration System, accessible at <https://register.bpa.org>.
 - Click on the “Conferences” tab and then select the “2027 National Virtual Events”.
 - There will be a \$20 fee for each team entry (*invoiced during event registration*).
 - Event registration can be purchased with your original invoice or with a new invoice after contestants’ registration.

- The registration deadline is no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time, on December 1, 2026.
- Contestants participating in the competition must be registered for the event prior to the submission deadline to be eligible.
- Only the team captain should complete the submission.

Technical Pre-Submit Specifications

What to Submit at https://upload.bpa.org	Saved File Name(s)	Deadline
Submit the following in one combined PDF: 1. Research Paper 2. Works Cited 3. BPA Release Form(s) 4. AI Usage and Documentation Form	V14-TeamID.pdf	January 15, 2027, 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time

Contest Competencies

1. Demonstrate integrity and accountability by adhering consistently to ethical principles, acting with honesty and fairness, and taking responsibility for the decisions and consequences that result from those actions
2. Apply transparent communication practices by clearly articulating the rationale behind decisions, developing and conveying an ethical vision, and ensuring stakeholders are informed and aligned
3. Demonstrate empathy by considering the perspectives, feelings, and needs of others in the decision-making process, treating all individuals with compassion and respect
4. Apply objectivity by grounding decisions in facts, evidence, and rational analysis, actively avoiding personal bias, favoritism, and self-interest
5. Demonstrate courage by making and defending difficult decisions that uphold ethical principles, even in the face of opposition, pressure, or potential negative consequences
6. Promote collaboration and inclusion by engaging stakeholders, seeking diverse perspectives, and fostering a participatory decision-making process that leads to fair and well-informed outcomes
7. Demonstrate adaptability and a commitment to continuous learning by remaining open to new information, feedback, and emerging ethical trends, and adjusting decisions when necessary to uphold ethical standards
8. Demonstrate ethical awareness by recognizing when a decision carries ethical weight, identifying concerns embedded in problems framed as technical, operational, or financial, and surfacing them before they become consequential
9. Apply legal and regulatory literacy by identifying the laws, disclosure requirements, and professional standards relevant to a decision, and by complying with their intent rather than only their letter
10. Apply stakeholder and consequence analysis by identifying all parties affected by a decision, including those absent from it, and by evaluating both immediate and long-term impacts.

Contest Specifications for this Event

- Teams should visit www.bpa.org/member-gateway/learnbpa and open the Principles of Ethics and Leadership course for event preparation.
- All teams will submit a research paper on the proposed case study and complete a 50-question objective test. The technical rubric and average team score will be used to determine the top 20 teams to advance to round two.
- The top 20 teams advancing to round two will receive a case study twist and give a presentation on the proposed solution to the twist, and lessons learned, to a panel of judges.
- The top 10 teams (combined technical, objective average team score, and presentation score) will be invited to the National Leadership Conference.
- The research paper must *not* exceed three (3) pages single-sided (excluding Works Cited). Follow the Report format located in the *Style & Reference Manual*. (Note: no Title Page is required.) Header information on the first page of the report should be as follows: Contestant ID Number (Sender's ID Number - XXXXXXXX), Julie Smith (Recipient's Name), Human Resources Department (Recipient's

Department), and Current Date. Any report submitted beyond the maximum number of pages will be *disqualified*. In-text citations are required throughout the paper.

- Submit the URL to the final Project Files including the research paper, the Works Cited and BPA Release Form(s) in a combined PDF file to <https://upload.bpa.org> no later than 11:59 p.m. Eastern Time on January 15, 2027.
- Advisors of qualifying teams will be contacted to reserve a time for a videoconference presentation before a panel of judges. The dates and times for presentation reservations will be announced via email notification. Teams will be assigned to sections prior to the preliminary presentation.
- Length of presentation: no more than three (3) minutes for setup, no more than ten (10) minutes for the presentation, and no more than five (5) minutes for judges' questions.
- The top teams with the highest cumulative technical and presentation scores will be invited to attend the National Leadership Conference to be recognized for their outstanding efforts and to participate in the National Showcase.

Common Specifications for all BPA Judged Events

- Team ID is required for all submissions. Materials from non-registered members and/or those missing team ID cannot be accepted.
- The team is responsible for securing a BPA Release Form(s) from any person, including themselves, whose image or work is used in the project.
- The team is responsible for citing all sources, including themselves, on the Works Cited page for any work used on the project. It is the policy of Business Professionals of America to comply with copyright law. The *Style & Reference Manual* contains guidelines for Copyright and/or Fair Use. Contestants will be disqualified for violations of the guidelines.
- Materials must follow the organization's BPA Graphic Standards and make proper use of the BPA logo and/or organization's name. Refer to the BPA Graphic Standards in the *Style & Reference Manual*.
- Judges' comments will be returned digitally through the online judging system at the national level. Materials submitted for technical judging will *not* be returned and will *not* be available at NLC.

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Technical Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Team followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Team followed Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and Artificial Intelligence Usage and Citation Policy.				☐ Y ☐ N
Research Paper did not exceed three (3) pages single-sided (excluding Works Cited).				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to any question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Submission and Formatting (All points or none are awarded by the technical judge)				
Team submitted one (1) combined PDF file containing the Research Paper, Works Cited formatted according to the <i>Style & Reference Manual</i> and BPA Release Form(s).				/10
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-9 points	Meets Expectations 10-15 points	Above Expectations 16-20 points	Points Awarded
Introduction/Summary	Lacks clarity or fails to present key ethical issues.	Clearly summarizes the issue with logical analysis and supporting evidence.	Provides a compelling, well-supported summary that frames the ethical challenge.	/20
Comprehension of Topic	Shows limited understanding or misinterprets ethical concepts.	Demonstrates solid understanding of ethical principles and context.	Shows deep insight and thoughtful engagement with the ethical topic.	/20
Organization & Expansion of Ideas	Ideas are disorganized or lack development.	Ideas are logically structured and supported with relevant evidence.	Ideas are well-developed, insightful, and supported with strong ethical reasoning.	/20
Creativity	Lacks originality or relies on limited perspectives.	Demonstrates creativity with diverse and relevant resources.	Presents a unique and innovative ethical perspective with rich, varied sources.	/20
Overall Effectiveness of Analysis	Analysis is weak or unconvincing.	Analysis is logical and effectively supports conclusions.	Analysis is compelling, well-reasoned, and demonstrates ethical leadership.	/20
Writing Accuracy	Frequent grammar or spelling errors.	Contains some grammar or spelling errors.	Contains very few or no grammar or spelling errors.	/20
TOTAL TECHNICAL POINTS				/130

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Presentation Scoring Rubric

Required Elements (If any question results in a NO, please assign a score of 0)				
Team followed the topic.				☐ Y ☐ N
Team followed Copyright and/or Fair Use Guidelines and Artificial Intelligence Usage and Citation Policy.				☐ Y ☐ N
If answered no to either question, please stop scoring and provide a brief reason for the <i>disqualification</i> :				
Evaluation Criteria	Below Expectations 0-9 points	Meets Expectations 10-15 points	Above Expectations 16-20 points	Points Awarded
Opening & Summary	The introduction is unclear or missing, and the summary lacks relevance or completeness.	The introduction sets the stage appropriately, and the summary covers the main points with adequate clarity.	The introduction is engaging and well-structured, and the summary provides a clear, insightful wrap-up that reinforces key findings.	/20
Content of Presentation	Content is unclear, lacks relevance or depth.	Content is clear, relevant, and adequately developed.	Content is insightful, well-developed, and strongly supports the presentation goals.	/20
Presentation Effectiveness	Delivery is distracting or lacks flow and engagement.	Delivery is smooth with good voice projection, transitions, and presence.	Delivery is polished, engaging, and enhances the impact of the presentation.	/20
Judges Questions	Responses lack depth and fail to demonstrate a comprehensive understanding of the topic.	Some responses lack detail or clarity. The understanding of the topic is partially demonstrated.	Responses are detailed, insightful, and effectively address the judges' questions.	/20
Team Members	At least two original team members were present during the presentation.			/5
Timing	Setup lasted no longer than three (3) minutes, and the presentation lasted no more than ten (10) minutes.			/10
TOTAL PRESENTATION POINTS				/95

Props and/or additional items shall not be used as a basis for scoring.

PRESENTATION WILL BE STOPPED AT 10 MINUTES